



PROVIDENCE ENGLISH PRIVATE SCHOOL

E-Learning & E-Safety Policy

2026 – 2027

Approved for FS 2 – Year 13

POLICY REVIEWED BY

IT Coordinator, Child Protection Coordinator & Senior Leadership Team

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POLICY APPROVED BY

School Principal

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September 2027

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1 Aims & Objectives

Providence English Private School (PEPS) recognises that the internet and other digital technologies are an essential part of learning, communication and school administration in the 21st century, and that their use brings both significant educational benefit and potential risk. E-safety is treated at PEPS as a safeguarding matter, not merely an ICT matter, and all members of the school community share a responsibility for being aware of e-safety at all times, knowing the required procedures, and acting on them.

Our aims are:

- To maximise the educational and social benefits of the internet and digital technology for students and staff, while

minimising associated risks;

- To ensure that e-learning, blended learning and remote/online teaching at PEPS meet clear standards of quality, delivery and assessment integrity;
- To safeguard students from online risks including exposure to inappropriate content, cyberbullying, grooming, radicalisation and exploitation;
- To ensure staff, students and parents/guardians understand their respective responsibilities for online safety;
- To ensure clear, well-understood procedures exist for reporting and responding to e-safety concerns and incidents;
- To protect the personal data and privacy of students and staff in line with UAE data protection law.

2 Legal & Regulatory Framework

This policy is written to align with the following UAE federal, local and regulatory requirements, and with relevant international accreditation standards:

- **Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA):** e-safety, safeguarding and wellbeing standards for private schools;
- **UAE National Education Charter:** the Charter's digital literacy and future-skills pillars, embedded in curriculum and school practice;
- **Ministry of Education Student Code of Conduct:** provisions relating to the responsible use of school-issued devices, platforms and digital communication;
- **Federal Decree-Law No. 34 of 2021 (Cybercrime Law):** governs online harassment, impersonation, defamation and misuse of electronic devices and networks;
- **Federal Law No. 3 of 2016 on Child Rights (Wadeema's Law):** guarantees every child's right to protection from all forms of abuse, including online exploitation and harm;
- **Federal Decree-Law No. 45 of 2021 on the Protection of Personal Data:** governs the collection, processing and protection of personal data, including student images and records held on school systems;
- **Council of International Schools (CIS) Safeguarding Standards:** as a CIS member school, PEPS's approach to e-safety reflects CIS's safeguarding standards, which incorporate the recommendations of the International Taskforce on Child Protection;
- Ministry of Education Digital Wellbeing guidance, which informs this policy's approach to healthy technology use.

3 Rationale & Definitions

E-safety concerns the safe and responsible use of the internet, digital devices and online platforms, and is treated at PEPS as a safeguarding issue rather than a purely technical or ICT issue. This policy covers educational provision delivered, supported or assessed through means that do not require attendance at a particular class, time or location — including e-learning, distance learning, blended learning, flexible learning, instructor-led online training, and the use of web-based materials to supplement classroom teaching.

This policy should be read alongside the Digital Citizenship Policy, which sets out the values, principles and expected online conduct that underpin the practical arrangements described here.

4 Scope & Applicability

This policy applies to all students at PEPS, from FS 2 to Year 13, and to all staff, and covers:

- Use of the school's ICT systems, networks, learning platforms and school-issued accounts;
- E-learning, blended learning and remote/online teaching delivered by the school;
- Personal devices brought onto school premises, subject to the Behaviour & Discipline Policy;
- Photographs, videos and other personal data collected or published by the school;
- Online conduct during school-organised activities, including virtual lessons and online assessment.

5 Roles & Responsibilities

Governing Body

The Governing Body of PEPS will ensure that:

- A designated E-Safety Officer/IT Coordinator is appointed, receives appropriate ongoing training and support, and works closely with the Child Protection Coordinator;
- All staff are made aware of this policy and its arrangements, and have access to appropriate e-learning/e-safety training;
- A commitment to e-safety forms part of the school's safer recruitment and selection process;
- Students have a clear, easy means of reporting concerns to a nominated member of staff;
- Heads of Department or other designated staff are able to enter and monitor online/virtual lessons on an ad hoc basis.

E-Safety Officer / IT Coordinator

The E-Safety Officer will:

- Act as the first point of contact for breaches of e-safety and security, and liaise with the Child Protection Coordinator as appropriate;
- Ensure the school's ICT systems are reviewed regularly (at least weekly) with regard to security, and that virus/malware protection is kept up to date;
- Ensure staff know how to manage a user sharing inappropriate material during an online lesson or breakout session, including removing them where necessary;
- Ensure staff know how to report illegal content encountered online, both internally and to the relevant authorities.

Teachers

Teachers model safe, responsible online behaviour; supervise students' use of technology and online platforms during lessons; and report e-safety concerns to the E-Safety Officer or Child Protection Coordinator.

Students

Students are expected to use school ICT systems and online platforms responsibly, follow this policy and the Digital Citizenship Policy, and report any e-safety concerns to a trusted adult.

Parents / Guardians

Parents/Guardians are asked to support the school's e-safety arrangements at home, engage with guidance provided by the school, and inform the school promptly of any online safety concerns affecting their child.

6 Teaching, Learning & Remote/Blended Delivery

6.1 Benefits & Use of the Internet in Learning

The internet is a necessary tool for staff, students and the wider school community, providing access to a wide range of educational resources and opportunities for mentoring and peer support. Students are encouraged to question what they read, verify facts from more than one source, and are taught research techniques including the use of search engines and subject catalogues. Students are taught to acknowledge sources and respect copyright, and are given clear guidance on what internet use is and is not acceptable, appropriate to their age and maturity. Students are taught what to do if they encounter material that is distasteful, uncomfortable or threatening, and how to critically evaluate the material they access.

6.2 Delivery Standards for E-Learning & Blended Learning

Where all or part of a programme of study is delivered through e-learning, distance learning or blended learning, PEPS will ensure that students have access to:

- Clear information on the respective responsibilities of the school and the student for delivery of the programme;
- Module or unit descriptors setting out intended learning outcomes and teaching, learning and assessment methods;
- A clear schedule for delivery of study materials and assessment of work;
- Timetabled learner support, such as tutorial sessions or web-based conferences, and opportunities to give formal feedback on their experience.

Study materials, whether delivered by school staff or through web-based or other distribution channels, will meet the

school's expectations for quality of teaching and learning-support material, and provision will be subject to ongoing internal review.

6.3 Academic Integrity in Remote Assessment

Where assessment is conducted through remote or online methods, staff responsible for assessment will take reasonable steps to confirm that a student's submitted work is their own original work. This includes vigilance around the unauthorised use of AI tools in ways that breach academic integrity, in line with the Digital Citizenship Policy.

7 Managing Online Communication & Content

7.1 Email & Messaging

- Access to external personal e-mail accounts on school systems may be restricted;
- Students must not reveal personal details (their own or others'), such as home address or telephone number, in e-mail or personal web space, and must not arrange to meet anyone they have communicated with online;
- Staff should use official school communication channels (e.g. the school portal) to communicate with students about schoolwork;
- Incoming e-mail should be monitored, and attachments should not be opened unless the sender is known and trusted.

7.2 School Website & Published Content

- Editorial oversight will ensure the school website reflects the school's ethos, that information is accurate and well-presented, and that personal security is not compromised, including in the use of photographic material;
- The website will comply with the school's publication guidelines, and parents/guardians will be informed of the school's policy on taking and publishing images;
- Students are taught to consider the feelings of others when publishing material online; content that bullies, victimises or is otherwise offensive is unacceptable and will be addressed under the Behaviour & Discipline and Anti-Bullying Policies;
- Students will not access social networking sites on school systems, and are taught the importance of personal safety when using social media and messaging platforms outside school, in line with the Social Media Policy;
- The E-Safety Officer will carry out regular checks to ensure filtering methods remain appropriate, effective and reasonable.

7.3 Photographs & Videos

- Photographs and videos of students will only be published on the school website or official channels with the written consent of parents/guardians, obtained at enrolment and valid for the student's period of attendance at the school, other than at open events such as seminars, competitions, sports days or graduation ceremonies;
- Parents/guardians may withdraw this consent in writing at any time;
- Photographs taken at school events or educational activities may be displayed within the school before being archived or securely destroyed;
- The E-Safety Officer will ensure that printing of school photographs takes place on school premises, and that images held on school cameras or devices are transferred and deleted promptly, in line with the Data Protection Policy;
- Where photographs are taken by a party other than the school, the E-Safety Officer will ensure appropriate consent has been obtained and that unsupervised access to students is not permitted.

8 Mobile Phones & Personal Electronic Devices

8.1 Students

Students are permitted to bring personal mobile phones and electronic devices onto school premises. On arrival, students must deposit their device with their Section Supervisor for safekeeping; devices are returned at the end of the school day. Outside of this arrangement, a student's device may only be used in class where a teacher or Section Supervisor has specifically requested or permitted its use for a lesson activity. Use of a device without permission, or failure to deposit a device as required, will be addressed in line with the Behaviour & Discipline Policy and the BYOD Policy.

8.2 Staff

- Staff may bring personal mobile phones to work; the school accepts no responsibility for loss, theft or damage to personal devices;
- Staff must not use personal mobile phones during lessons or formal school time; phones should be switched off or silent during lesson time, with use limited to breaks or after school;
- Where use of a mobile phone during lesson time is required in an emergency, staff should seek permission from their Supervisor or Head of Department;
- Staff tablets and laptops used for school purposes must be registered with the IT office for compatibility and login permissions;
- Breaches of this section will be addressed in line with the school's Staff Code of Conduct.

9 ICT Security & Data Protection

- Personal data sent over school networks will be encrypted or otherwise secured, in line with Federal Decree-Law No. 45 of 2021 on the Protection of Personal Data and the school's Data Protection Policy;
- Unapproved system utilities or executable files will not be permitted in student work areas or as e-mail attachments;
- The E-Safety Officer will ensure school ICT systems have sufficient capacity for internet use and are protected by up-to-date passwords and access controls, in line with the Password Policy.

10 Handling E-Safety Concerns, Incidents & Sanctions

All members of the PEPS community should feel able to raise any e-safety concern with the E-Safety Officer without hesitation. E-safety is treated as a safeguarding matter and is closely linked to the Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy, Behaviour & Discipline Policy, Anti-Bullying Policy, Social Media Policy, BYOD Policy, Acceptable Use Policy and Wellbeing Policy.

- Any complaint concerning staff or student misuse of the internet or school ICT systems must be reported to the E-Safety Officer immediately;
- Concerns that raise a safeguarding issue will be referred immediately to the Child Protection Coordinator and handled under the Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy;
- Sanctions for misuse may include interview or counselling by an appropriate member of staff, informing parents/guardians, and temporary or extended removal of internet access, which may affect access to files held on the school system, including coursework, in line with the Behaviour & Discipline Policy;
- General complaints should be handled in line with the school's Complaints Policy.

11 Parent / Guardian Support & Consent

- Parents/guardians will be informed of this policy, which is available on the school website;
- Any e-safety issue involving a student will be handled sensitively, informing parents/guardians without undue alarm;
- The school will make advice available to parents/guardians on filtering systems and appropriate educational and leisure use of the internet at home;
- The school will encourage parents, including through the Parents' Committee, to attend practical sessions on safe internet use at home;
- Adult users of school ICT systems will be asked to sign the school's Acceptable Use Policy;
- Parents/guardians of students under 18 years of age will be required to sign the Acceptable Use Policy on behalf of their child;
- Password security is set out in the school's Password Policy.

12 Policy Links

- Behaviour & Discipline Policy
- Digital Citizenship Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy

- Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy
- Social Media Policy
- BYOD Policy
- Acceptable Use Policy
- Password Policy
- Data Protection Policy
- Wellbeing Policy

13 Monitoring & Evaluation

This policy sits under the oversight of the Governing Body, which delegates day-to-day implementation to the Senior Leadership Team. Its effectiveness will be reviewed annually by the E-Safety Officer/IT Coordinator, the Child Protection Coordinator and the Senior Leadership Team, or sooner if required by changes in SPEA/MOE regulation or UAE federal law. Ongoing e-safety incidents will be reported to the Governing Body and school leadership as they arise.

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